

When I opened the account, I set up automatic contributions. Every two weeks I had \$40 taken from my checking account and deposited to my investing account. I've gradually increased my contribution amounts since then.

Q. You are now debt-free. What were some key things you did to pay off your student loan debt?

A. I was very mindful of the "big three" expenses: rent, food, and transportation. Living in NYC is expensive, but there are ways to keep your costs low. When I graduated from law school, instead of moving into a fancy high-rise apartment in the middle of the city, I stayed in my studio apartment in Harlem. About a year later I moved in with my partner and share the rent costs for our one-bedroom apartment. A decent lunch and a snack in NYC can easily cost \$15. I meal-prepped my lunches and snacks for four of the five weekdays, allowing myself to buy lunch on Fridays as a treat. I don't use any food delivery apps because those delivery fees add up fast! Also, because I live in NYC, there is no real need for a car so I not only saved on the cost of a car, but also on insurance, gas, tolls, parking, maintenance, etc.

Q. Now that your debt is paid off, how will you be accelerating your investing plans and what does your investment approach look like?

A. I'm not planning on increasing my lifestyle by much, so I plan on putting most of the money that I was using to pay off my debt toward investing. I will likely look into low-cost index funds because, as mentioned, I take a passive approach to investing and want to have a well-diversified investment portfolio.

Q. As a woman, why is investing so important to you?

A. My parents immigrated to this country with practically nothing. They weren't able to teach me about investing because they were too busy trying to put food on the table. As the daughter of immigrants, it is my duty to show my parents that all of their sacrifices were well worth it and to help them financially as they get older. I want to build real generational wealth so that my children and my children's children will never lack and will benefit from the seeds that I plant today. I also want to show young women